

Episode 132: Once Upon a Time... 76 – 1994 Part 10 – *Sailor Moon S* Movie

Colour Carbon Blues

August arrived. Daily scorching heat in Tokyo. Aren't there fewer cicadas this year?

Our house is next to a park, and while cicadas sing reasonably during the day, their voices stop completely in the evening. Last year and the year before, cicada choruses that started with sunrise continued all day, sometimes until night. This year is remarkably quiet.

I don't know about other areas, but Nakano definitely has fewer cicadas this year.

Cicadas spend about seven years underground. Seven years ago, perhaps that year also had few cicadas like this year. Seven years ago? What kind of year was it? What work was I doing?

And seven years from now, will it be another summer with few cicadas?

Now then.

Sailor Moon S movie—this time's enemy was snow and ice queen Princess Snow Kaguya and her minions. Since it was an original creator's written story, naturally enemy character image illustrations from the original creator were sent.

Hmm, pure white (wry laugh).

That's right. Since it's "snow and ice" imagery, that's understandable, but both queen and minions were completely white from top to bottom. Sure, drawn as manga illustration style, it probably looked good, but in this anime version that couldn't just be OK. We had to somehow create queen-like dignity and hierarchy differences from minions. That

said, we didn't want to increase colour count much, and it should still feel like "snow" and "ice."

So I tried making "how about this?" colour samples first. For minions "Snow Dancers," almost matching original illustration imagery—skin, hair, clothes all completely white with no colour separation. Shadow colours unified in CB-system light blue.

Queen Princess Snow Kaguya also based on original illustrations with white for skin and clothes, N-system light blue for hair and accessories. Upper body had thin veil-like gown drawn in. Plus head-to-foot veils layered with semi-transparent double brush processing. I tried unifying in white to blue (light blue) or white to light purple feeling.

But somehow it didn't feel quite right. The impression was somehow hard. While colours were unified in white base, the transparency—or "coldness"—was pointing in a slightly wrong direction.

"Ah, the main lines (outlines) are too hard."

Normal animation machine trace uses black carbon, making outlines black. This doesn't matter for regular characters like Usagi who use voluminous colours for skin, hair, and clothes, but this time's queen and minions were basically white. So white with black outlines inevitably looked hard—or rather dirty.

So I thought of coloured carbon.

As I may have written somewhere before, besides black carbon there are brown, pink, green, white and other coloured carbons. Among these, I thought about trying blue first.

I tried putting blue carbon lines on the previous colour samples. Snow Dancers flying around energetically looked great! Making main lines blue added transparency and speed to characters for good balance. But Queen Snow Kaguya was still lacking somehow. She

resembled the minions too much. Perhaps we should fundamentally reconsider by departing from original illustrations?

So I boldly remade painting colours departing from white. And for main line colours, I used white carbon. I stopped using white for skin and hair painting colours, and to make white outlines stand out, I changed painting colours to light blue-system colours respectively. Honestly, they looked completely different from original illustrations (sweat). Actually in the main feature screen, snow, wind, or beam technique effects would layer on top, so considering that, maybe this much colour would be fine?

Colour samples organised with such thinking were shown to main staff including producer, director, animation director, and art director, with slight adjustments to complete decisions. Sent to original creator side. "Maybe they'll say 'this is different from what I drew!' and send it back..." I was somewhat apprehensive. Incidentally, other guests Sora Kakeru and Nayotake Himeko were created in colours almost exactly matching original illustrations.

But such worries proved groundless—while there were some correction notes, basically everything got OK!

Now main feature work could start... but this colour carbon proved more troublesome than imagined.

(10.08.03)